

Sports T20 WORLD CUP



Stars of Twenty20

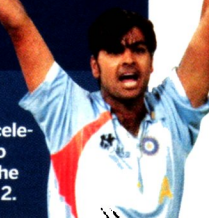
« **GAUTAM GAMBHIR**
The left-handed opener broke through as India's top scorer in the 2007 World T20 and has been on a great run since.



YUSUF PATHAN »
The big man who bowls wearing sunglasses at night can change matches with the bat in a matter of overs. His strike rate for India a staggering 203.57.



« **SURESH RAINA**
Top scorer amongst all Indian batsmen in IPL 2, Raina also played partnership breaker with the ball. In the field is India's inner ring panther.



R.P. SINGH »
Swing king Singh celebrated his return to Indian ranks with the most wickets in IPL 2.

Photographs by REUTERS

dle of a work week, the Indians out-pointed their famous rivals with pace-man Ishant Sharma saying it was a practice match only for the ICC. Since its 2007 World T20 win, Dhoni's team has grown in stature and importantly, composure. It has won 31 of its 51 one-day internationals, with series wins in Australia, Sri Lanka and New Zealand.

Its T20 International experience may have been lukewarm since then, two wins in five, but quality T20 game time has come from a competition (or should we call that a 'product' or a 'property') that promises, threatens even, to change cricket forever.

Every man on Dhoni's squad has had two seasons of the Indian Premier League (IPL), which stripped of its showbiz quotient, is a high-quality T20 event that has given cricketers the chance to play 28 matches in intense, five-week bursts.

So if the performances of the Indian team in the 2009 IPL (see box) are an indicator of form, then the middle-order is striking the ball cleanly, swing exponents R.P. Singh, (leading wicket-taker in the IPL), Irfan Pathan and Praveen Kumar and spin specialists Harbhajan Singh and Pragyan Ojha have all found rhythm.

The bookies in England certainly think so, having made India the odds-on favourite along with South Africa at 3-1 which is enough to make all Indians nervous (see box). It is not just wishful thinking because Sachin Tendulkar too believes "strength and balance" are on India's side.

What is certainly not is the creakiness that comes from a playing calendar that has gone months without pause. Dhoni's back threatens to be temperamental. Zaheer Khan, the leader of the bowling attack has a bad shoulder. Bad enough as it could be, Virender Sehwag's 'niggle' also seems to have afflicted Dhoni with bouts of baffling ambiguity around Sehwag's return to the top of the order. Team coach

» FORMBOOK: INDIA'S TWENTY

PLAYERS	MATCHES	RUNS	AVG
M.S. DHONI	14	332	41.5
VIRENDER SEHWAG	11	198	19.8
GAUTAM GAMBHIR	15	286	22
SURESH RAINA	14	434	31
YUVRAJ SINGH	14	340	28.33
ROHIT SHARMA	16	362	27.84
YUSUF PATHAN	13	243	20.25
RAVINDER JADEJA	13	295	26.81
IRFAN PATHAN	14	196	19.6
PRAVEEN KUMAR	13	65	13
HARBHAJAN SINGH	13	84	10.5
PRAGYAN OJHA	15	1	0.33
ZAHEER KHAN	6	8	8
R.P. SINGH	16	8	2
ISHANT SHARMA	11	16	8

PRASHANT CHAUDHARY

Gary Kirsten believes "mental fatigue" will be his team's biggest challenge. But since no one opted out of the IPL to stay 'fresh' for India, it implies that all excuses must necessarily be shelved right away.

Sanjay Manjrekar, former India batsman and one of the foremost thinkers on the game today, says, "India are the strongest team on paper but that doesn't mean they are going to win." It's a bit of a dampener given the enthusiasm being generated across and over the airways in India. Surely its mastery of the Akram equation should logically give India an advantage because they seem to play big games in the image of their skipper. No matter what you feel, never let it show.

The reason why India came through in 2007 was a combination of factors: young players and a new captain eager to prove themselves, a lack of inhibition

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